First Apartment Checklist

Paperwork, safety and tools, kitchen and bathroom: what to buy and set up.

Before you move in

- [ ] Read the lease: rent date, deposit, who pays which utilities — Before
- [ ] Buy renters insurance (your landlord's policy won't cover your things) — Before
- [ ] Book electric, gas, water and internet about a month ahead — Before
- [ ] File a USPS change of address (online fee $1.25) — Before
- [ ] Ask for a move-in inspection sheet — Before
- [ ] Built before 1978? Ask for the lead paint disclosure — Before
- [ ] Set a budget: rent plus utilities at or under about 30% of income — Before

Kitchen

- [ ] Skillet, saucepan and a sheet pan — Week 1
- [ ] Chef's knife and two cutting boards (one for raw meat) — Week 1
- [ ] 4 plates, bowls, mugs and glasses; cutlery — Day 1
- [ ] Spatula, wooden spoon, tongs, can opener — Week 1
- [ ] Measuring cups, mixing bowl, colander — Later
- [ ] Food thermometer and a fridge thermometer — Week 1
- [ ] Food storage containers — Later
- [ ] Dish soap, sponges, dish towels or rack — Day 1
- [ ] Trash can and bags — Day 1

Safety and tools

- [ ] Test every smoke alarm (inside and outside bedrooms) — Day 1
- [ ] CO alarm outside each sleeping area and on every level — Day 1
- [ ] Multipurpose (ABC) fire extinguisher — Week 1
- [ ] Flashlight, spare batteries and a first aid kit — Day 1
- [ ] Basic toolkit: hammer, screwdrivers, tape measure, pliers — Week 1
- [ ] Anti-tip kits for dressers, bookcases and the TV — Week 1
- [ ] Surge protector and an extension cord (temporary use only) — Week 1
- [ ] Plunger (before you need it) — Day 1

Bathroom

- [ ] Toilet paper, hand soap, hand towel — Day 1
- [ ] Shower curtain, liner and rings — Day 1
- [ ] 2 bath towels and a bath mat — Day 1
- [ ] Toilet brush and small trash can — Week 1
- [ ] Shower caddy or shelf — Later
- [ ] Basic medicines and bandages — Week 1

First Apartment Checklist

Bedroom, living room, cleaning and your first week, plus when you need each item.

Bedroom

- [ ] Mattress that fits the room (measure first) — Day 1
- [ ] Mattress protector or encasement — Day 1
- [ ] Two sets of sheets, pillows, comforter — Day 1
- [ ] Blackout curtains or blinds — Week 1
- [ ] Hangers and a laundry hamper — Week 1
- [ ] Bedside lamp — Later

First week in

- [ ] Photograph every room and note every scratch or stain — Day 1
- [ ] Find the breaker panel and the water shut-off — Week 1
- [ ] Save the landlord and maintenance contacts — Day 1
- [ ] Plan 2 ways out of every room in a fire — Week 1
- [ ] Check fridge 40°F or below, freezer 0°F or below — Week 1
- [ ] Anchor tall furniture and the TV — Week 1

Living room

- [ ] Somewhere to sit (secondhand is fine, but inspect it) — Later
- [ ] Floor lamp and LED bulbs — Week 1
- [ ] Curtains or blinds for privacy — Week 1
- [ ] Rug and a small table — Later
- [ ] Wall hooks and picture hangers — Later

Cleaning and laundry

- [ ] All-purpose cleaner and an EPA-registered disinfectant — Day 1
- [ ] Rubber gloves and microfiber cloths — Day 1
- [ ] Broom and dustpan, or a vacuum — Week 1
- [ ] Mop or floor wipes — Later
- [ ] Laundry detergent and a drying rack — Week 1
- [ ] Paper towels — Day 1

When you need it

Before	before moving day
Day 1	for your first night
Week 1	in the first week
Later	when budget allows

Before you shop

Measure first: doorways, stairs and the bedroom before you buy a bed or sofa.

Day 1 items first: so the first night has light, a bed, a towel and toilet paper.

Borrow or buy used: for the Later items, and inspect secondhand furniture for bed bugs.

Keep receipts: and photos of what you own for renters insurance.